

Crispian Teague and The Ornate Museum
By: Caleb Magill

Characters

?1&2:	Unknown Dialoguer
DC:	The Divine Commentator
CT:	Crispian Teague
LG:	Little Girl
HO1-8:	Homeowner
OMC:	Old Man Captain
OMS:	Old Man Stoic
OMW:	Old Man Watchman

Prelude

Imagine suddenly both time and space collapsing into a finite, tangible point of singularity.

- ?1:** “Do you think he’ll ever wake up?”
- ?2:** “That I cannot say; he has suffered serious head trauma.”
- ?1:** “But he’s still breathing, I mean he’s alive, right?”
- ?2:** “Yes of course he’s alive, he’s just in a deep unconsciousness right now.”
- ?1:** “Do you think he can hear us?”
- ?2:** “That I cannot say.”
- ?1:** “Do you think he’s dreaming?”
- ?2:** “That I cannot say either, he very well could be.”
- ?1:** “Well, what do you think he’s dreaming about?”
- ?2:** “You ask of me that of which I cannot say. Though suppose he is; surely it’s something pleasant.”

...

DC: "Archeologists were right, humans really did only inhabit the earth for a very brief time.

And no more confounding of an exit than which could be reasonably conceived!
Anyways, where were we?
Ah yes, the Microcosal Museum!
How ornate, how contrived.
It's all your species' legacy has left, summarized!
Its furnishings imported from that of the mind."

Placed atop a soulless, infinitely-spanning plane, protruded an incalculably daunting megastructure. From a distance a monolith, yet up close an edifice; as banks and courthouses in the era we know contain carvings of civic inscriptions, what was etched into the external faces of this building must've been every word forming in combination every phrase ever echoed into the abyss. What was most polarizing however, upon further inspection (of the awe-inspiring scene), was the contrast in aesthetic between the creation and the ground for which it sat. Back on the plane: a monotone, neutral pastel which must've been indivisible; the echo which it'd emanate, when walked upon, perplexing, as there seemed no other surface parallel in the scene for which sound could deflect. Upon a very-close examination; there seemed in fact no abrasions anywhere to hint at its composition, no irregularities in level such to reveal the distinct application of this otherwise unnatural color, nor imperfections which could reveal how possibly such a ground could've been humanistically constructed.

Standing in the foreground was one Crispian Teague; a model for the modern portrayal of the American dreamer. A nomad by nature, he found himself (in all his free-spiritedness) just as puzzled as he'd had by any other newly-discovered destination:

CT: "Where am I?"

DC: "Why, you're at the gates of humanity's id of course!

It screams into the void, beckoning to be acknowledged.

Now finally it is to be received."

The doors at the designs' entrance stood a tall twenty feet into the air: of solid wood by construction, they themselves possessed enough opulence to forego any pretended portrayal of authority- it was apparent to whom they served, and for which they represented.

CT: "But *why* am I here?"

I mean, how'd I get here?"

DC: "Well, nature manifested it!

And now you are to bear witness to all that beholds it."

The presentation (to Teague) seemed all so unnerving, serving moreso as a precaution rather than anything of a sensible palatability. Inscribed promptly above said doors was the phrase: Quae sepselire conamur, ea nobis sunt adeunda, si liberi esse volumus. Their pending embarkment depended now only on the consent of Crispian Teague:

DC: "So, shall I show you around?"

CT: "Sure, I guess."

The Axiom of Whores

Suddenly the two were vaporized, and subsequently rematerialized inside the confines of what appeared to be a long-deserted hall. Decrepit and dimly-lit, the air around them gave off a chilling, inaffectionate nip.

DC: "Look before you:"

Housed within these walls sat abandoned perhaps fifty grotesque mannequins; some with male, others female features, positioned unnaturally; almost as if displaying a mocking athleticism. Few bare, though most adorning some degree of erotic garment. The place was trashed. Contrived, but trashed. It all looked so foreign to that of which Teague was familiar; props with unknown branding and use, furniture with unusual curvature, he noticed almost immediately however the consistent emblem stitched onto a few of the (presumably womens') tops.

CT: "What is this emblem?"

DC: "Why, that would be the emblem of the nation of Condorcet."

CT: "Nation of Condorcet?"

DC: "Yes, their culture permeated the lands of a better part of a continent for a better part of a millennia."

CT: "And how did their branding end up here?"

DC: "Well, they were partying of course!

Their existence was founded on the cornerstone of an enlightened liberalism.

They very much believed in the indelibility and independence of the individual, so much so it became their prime obsession!

But they weren't much like the Swiss of your time, no, they were instead much more transfixed on the idea of suspending the disposition of metaphysics."

CT: "I'm not sure I understand- why are all these mannequins here?"

DC: "Why, that would be because they are an exhibit, and this is a museum."

CT: "Ok- wait, did you really just-

Nevermind, I meant why are they displayed like this?

Like what are all these props?"

DC: "Well, they are indeed an exhibit for a reason.

It began at conception in fact; their destruction that is.

You'll see there are many such implications to my simple phrasings.

Now, where do I begin?

You see..."

CT: "And why are they posing so... erotically?"

DC: "That's the thing; they- well, that brought about their eventual end in fact.

This 'suspension of the disposition of metaphysics' was undertaken in a rather ignorant manner...

Just as the newfound fortune of many allow an amnesia to take hold, such to forget those that helped them along the way, so too did this nation forget its origins.

Their forebears were devout libertines, and even in their latter reformations, they retained a particular interest in sexual expression...

Sexual empowerment!

First it was determined to elide the acts of 'hooking up' and 'lovemaking'; that is the distinction between the casual, pleasure-inducing action, and the reserved, taboo expression of love.

This wasn't met with particular difficulty; their technology and population had grown to a point at which there posed no overwhelming external threat to their existence.

Other socioeconomic initiatives led to the disestablishment of the family model entirely.

It now made no difference the significance to whom you had sexual relations with.

They next resolved to tabooize the concept of the 'relationship'; it helped they came from an ancestry versed in propaganda.

Actually, anything that implied a reserved exclusivity became frowned-upon, it might not shock you to know they were staunch communists.

Furthermore, they normalized the display of these casual relations in public life; no more were you to hide your intentions behind innocent pretense.

And if it's what everyone lusted for in the first place, why hide it?

Though would you expect something now so plentiful and common to become evermore a vice?

They became heathens of the flesh.

Their society broke down because they became obsessed with a procreative act that bore no children.

Because they attested no necessity for offspring.

Because the ends of their artificial advancement could combat any problem for them.

Because they were too preoccupied with their own self-actualization.

Because they'd simply conquered nature."

CT: "But I don't understand, how can one 'conquer nature'?"

DC: "They say anyone can do anything if they put their mind to it!

Look at that mannequin there:"

Seated in an upright position ontop of the arm-like protrusion of what appeared to be a couch sat one disheveled-looking mannequin: wearing what remained of a wig, it was covered with what must've been several millimeters of dust. Atop the wig sat a crownlike ornament; assumingly of copper as it'd apparently oxidized.

DC: "That crown must've been absolutely stunning at the time of its conception, though what remains of it now?

It's decayed due to the factor of time of course.

Even the pores of the wood which composes its face will one day decay.

It's *all* impermanent.

And so it was; they'd enjoyed the conquest, though inevitably it must have come to an end.

Their only autonomy was choosing their timeframe."

CT: "Couldn't they have seen their problem ahead of time?

DC: "Retrospect is a powerful tool.

That's why we have museums after all!

Anyways, shall we proceed to the next exhibit?"

Without waiting for consent, a door suddenly revealed itself in the corner of the room, just beyond an orgy of mannequins of course.

Innocence

After passing through the doorway, Teague was met with an entirely different environment from whence he'd just occupied. Though much to his delight, it appeared a scene which felt very homely to himself: an orderly suburban sprawl. Rows of organized houses with uniform trimmings, tidy frontlawns, and one to four vehicles occupying each of the driveways; all seemingly from the same set of 2010s-era models. A long, winding paved road bisected the two rows. The air smelled somewhere between grass clippings and freshly-laid tar.

CT: "What is this place?"

DC: "Why, it'd be just another inconspicuous neighborhood of course.

The scene which many imagine as their destination to retire to; to make and raise families within."

CT: "But why this neighborhood specifically then?"

DC: "You needn't get lost in the details.

Infact this scene could be contrived amidst the backdrop of a plenty of landscapes."

Just as he said this, a girl enters: she appears near-tidy; her longsocks, to her dress, and even to the ribbons in her hair appear in order, and yet she wears a pensive, near-apprehensive gaze.

DC: "Just focus on the presentation before you.

Besides, it really is a nice day out.”

She begins her approach to the house on her left, and upon reaching the doorway, she knocks:

LG: “Excuse me ma’am; I don’t mean to intrude, but I am lost and have no place to stay.”

HO1: “Oh you poor thing, though I’m afraid I can be of no service.”

And abruptly, the door shuts.

DC: “You see, there is a very distinct attribute that separates your species apart from others, do you know what that is?”

Though before he had the time to respond, the girl was already at the house across the street, and had promptly rang the doorbell:

HO2: “Yes?”

LG: “Hello sir, I mean not to be a burden, but I’ve found myself lost and could use your help.”

HO2: “Well, what a shame, you must be afraid.

But I’m unable to do anything for you, sorry.”

And the door shuts.

DC: “It’s hope.”

The little girl walks off the porch and skips over a few of the miscellaneous cracks that violate the soundness of the concrete sidewalk. She then approaches the next house, again to her right:

LG: “Ma’am? I’m without a home or family.”

HO3: “I’m sorry, I cannot assist you.”

And the door shuts.

DC: “It’s the hope that the good in this world will prevail.”

Like clockwork, she’s on the left porch now:

LG: “Sir, I have no place to stay!”

HO4: “I’m afraid I can’t be of service.”

DC: “It’s the hope that, eventually, it will all work out.”

The door shuts in her face. Unphased, she proceeds to walk further down the street. The routine proceeds:

LG: “Sir, I need your help!”

HO5: “I’m sorry, no.”

And the door closes. Then to the right:

LG: “Ma’am, I’m in need of assistance!”

HO6: “I’m sorry, no.”

DC: “And there exists such a multitude of opportunity, atleast seemingly.

Surely it’s only a matter of finding it.”

Again she walks further down the street, now to the end of it. The view of Teague (who’s been following omnisciently and unseen) is now transfixed on the last two houses. She first moves toward the left:

DC: “But really we’re all just trying to get by.

And everyone’s so sympathetic toward that for which they want no part of.”

LG: “Excuse me ma’am; I’m lost and I’m scared.

Could you assist me?”

HO7: “Oh you poor thing, I take great pity on you.

Though I’m afraid I cannot allow your stay, for my house is full and I must keep my own children well-fed.”

And the door shuts.

DC: “But the good *must* prevail, right?”

Then the right; a rather rundown-looking house. It sat much contrastingly opposed to its neighbors.

DC: “No, I refuse to believe otherwise.”

She first tries the doorbell.

DC: “Some don’t know any better, and others are taught to ignore instinct.

Regardless, when someone really needs refuge, any house looks like a home.”

The doorbell doesn’t work, and so the little girl instead knocks:

LG: “Sir; I’ve lost my family, and don’t know where I am!”

HO8: “Why, what’s a pretty little thing like you without a family?

Of course you can stay here.”

The homeowner extends his arm and rapidly pulls the girl into the house, and the door promptly shuts.

DC: “And the masses are often more willful in accepting a falsity rather than an occasional, uncomfortable truth.

In fact, it's all tragic really.

Crispian; she never left that home."

Disjointedly, the sun rapidly begins to set.

DC: "Do you understand what I am saying?"

CT: "I- I'm not sure, I..."

DC: "Crispian, she would never go on to find her family.

Those long locks and yellow plaid dress would never again see the light of day.

She would go on to be murdered in that house, Crispian!"

CT: "But why?"

Why would you bring me here?

I don't understand what any of this means!"

Though by this point the Divine Commentator had already turned away from the houses and toward the street in which they came. Nonconforming, Teague plead his case:

CT: "Please just let me leave this place then!

All of this, I just want this to all be over!"

The Divine Commentator Turns Around:

DC: "Don't you remember?"

You asked for this!"

Disoriented and distraught, Crispian Teague locked eyes with the divine Commentator and refused to avert his gaze. Transfixed, the wind at once picked up (in a rather violent nature), and the sun hastily (unnaturally) fell below the sky and suddenly it was night.

The light of the moon increased in intensity, and the shadow cast over the Divine Commentator gave a rather harrowing appearance. It was all so abrupt, then thunder boomed nearby, and the lighting of the moon was replaced with lightning. Freezing rain began to fall and suddenly it was hail; from pebbles to grapes to golf balls, their size rapidly increased, and it seemed as if all of nature was at once in an attempt to thwart Teague's composure.

Then, after its failure, the scene suddenly fell silent.

Maximalism and Perfectionism

At once the floor beneath them caved, and at a rapid speed they descended toward (what appeared to be) Hell. An anarchic firescape surrounded Teague on all sides: incomprehensible creatures with impossible features crawling ontop of the otherwise dead crust. Brooks of magma splicing the surface; the heatwaves were visible, though with everything being so hot to begin with it was hardly noticeable. Teague was perhaps relieved to experience no more hotness than what was typical for that of a sauna. Himself situated on a solid piece of mantle.

DC: “It’s all so tragic!”

The Divine Commentator ascended to a position overlooking Teague and the great expanses of this dystopian terrain:

DC: “Why is it that *I*- that *she* is born into a world so wrought with corruption?”

The nature of these creatures was apparent, and their conduct abhorrent: their appearance couldn’t be missed, and the ones that couldn’t be seen could still be heard. They were all moaning or shrieking in their chaotic patterns, scales covered much of their exteriors as if crustaceans or mollusks of earth. It was unobservable their mating, but it surely must’ve been violent.

DC: “What you see now is a demonstration of the violence of nature.”

Suddenly, one not too dissimilar from an earthly centipede breached the surface of the mantle Teague was standing ontop of. Curiously, it appeared mangled: its legs contorting in ungraceful movements, an uneven pattern of hardened scales exposed parts of soft fleshy innards.

DC: “And nature does indeed make mistakes.
You can crush it if you’d like.”

CT: “Actually, I’d rather not.”

Uncomfortably, Teague regressed toward a different corner, centipede-free.

DC: “Why, if they bother you, you should.

There’re tens of thousands that harbor themselves into every square mile of ground in this place.

And they’re all ceaseless and relentless.

Their goal is simply to sustain their capacity of movement; to mate and to survive.”

CT: “Is that not what animals do?”

DC: “Yes, though they aren’t satiable.

They continue to hunt and mate, and they infact cannibalize to sustain themselves.

And in doubt, they will even eat their own offspring.”

Two like creatures begin attacking one-another. Both possessing large mandibles, they take turns tearing chunks of scales and flesh from eachother. Another suddenly falls into a lava lake.

DC: “The adult males compete with eachother, destroying themselves in the process.” And this firescape bore no significance beyond a polarizing, conspicuous warehouse that stood some distance out. Naturally, in the next moment that he blinked, Teague suddenly found himself standing within its walls:

DC: “Now look before you:

What do you see?”

Situated at its center; immediately infront of him stretched a conveyor belt; its origins obscured, and positioned atop it was a single, inscrutable model:

CT: “Well, it appears to be a church of some kind.”

DC: “No!

It’s the reconstructed Basilica of Saint-Denis; the epoch of the Gothic Architectural movement.

Does it appear to you as just some church?”

CT: “I had no idea- it just looks to me like a church, albeit grand.”

DC: “Ah!

But that’s just it;

A whole generation of people pointed at that and thought:

‘Look; we did that’.”

The Basilica in its miniature size sat rotating atop a spinplate.

DC: “But can you imagine being beholden to something so...

Imperfect?

I mean God, if they only knew how much more the way they had to go.

And that there’d be one similar situated in every microstate and county in the following decades.”

Teague could make out microfigures dotting the perimeter of the structure.

DC: “Now press that button, the big red one in front of you.”

CT: “What will it do?”

DC: “You dare to question my authority?
I’m the facilitator of your experience!”

Teague promptly presses the button. And suddenly the entirety of the structure was consumed in a great fireball. The fireball is of course only great in scale with respect to the structure, rather, all Teague feels is a heat as if sitting next to a bonfire.

DC: “Fuck yes!
Isn’t the release so wholly liberating?”

Then the light died down and the remaining plume gradually dissipated. Finally with enough visibility it was revealed the now-empty surface of the conveyor belt.

DC: “And you know what I find so genuinely offensive?”

Just then another microstructure moved toward Teague.

DC: “The ignorant satisfaction.”

This one was a render of the Palace of Versailles.

DC: “You see here; the King conceived of an artificial property so grand that it’d simply cease to be a ‘land’ in the sense of its belonging to nature.
He’d envisioned it’d house his eternal dynasty.”

The opulence of its shrubbery too was depicted.

DC: “And after he’d refined the shape and edges of every topiary in his vicinity, he became satisfied.

And so, he rested.

And every morning, his continued satisfaction was roused upon the confirmation that the landscapers were to arrive and to perform their days’ maintenance.”

Indeed, the vegetation in their tiny form appeared perfectly cut.

DC: “But tell me; what’s the value in upholding this status-quo if its perimeter is so infested with this corruption- this plague?

Is it not an inevitability it’ll eventually take over anyway?

I hate that.

I hate them.

Press the button.”

The button is once again pressed, and a fireball ensues. After a brief moment, another

minimodel is moved in front of him:

DC: “Now look at this one here:”

Just as with the last, it sat situated on a spinplate; and the microfigures dotted it: some housed within its delicate walls, others not too far from its base.

DC: “It’s genuinely the most beautiful thing I’ve ever laid my eyes on:

It’s iconic; the elegant spiraling of the steel, intertwined with the grandeur of its general geometry.

And they both converge perfectly complimentary against the framing of the masonry.

It’s the point at which architecture has itself embodied art, and whose purpose is its artform.

It’s everything I can imagine I’ve ever wanted.”

Teague too was transfixed.

DC: “But there must be something just past it.

Something even more marvelous.

I need to see *that* thing before I can properly assess this one.”

The light of Hell from outside bounced beautifully off the panes at the forefront.

DC: “Quick- you must destroy this structure, for whatever succeeds it will surely be the pinnacle!”

CT: “But I don’t want to!

I like this one.”

DC: “But you must!

You must trust me that there is something greater just past this!”

After some hesitation, Teague presses the button. The object was at once consumed in a great fireball, just as its predecessors, and nothing remained of it upon dissipation. The conveyor belt starts out again, though this time no new object is presented, rather it’s simply an empty spinplate:

DC: “Oh, right.

But can you imagine it?

The thing that holds enough significance that people will look at you and say:

‘That’s it!’

‘You’ve done it.’

‘It’s perfect- nay, it’s enough’...

‘To me.’

Can you imagine?”

And again without allowing for the relief of resolution, the Divine Commentator simply moved to take an ascendant position overlooking Teague. He snapped his fingers (as if needing an external signal to will it), and suddenly Teague’s eyes were closed and everything was quiet.

On Math and God and Society

Teague first opened his eyes, whereupon he was met with the blinding light of the sun’s rays reflecting seamlessly off the vast body of water surrounding himself in every direction. The sea, aquamarine and translucent, seemed to bear no landscapes in his ship’s present direction. After getting his bearings, he first looked about for the Divine Commentator:

CT: “I don’t understand- where did he go?”

(said Teague out loud) Though this time no narrative voice followed. Rather, for the first time since the inception of this experience, Crispian Teague found himself utterly alone. Situated in his boat no more than himself was but a set of oars, for which the small wooden vessel, whilst competing against the current, was to be guided by. In the far distance and in the opposite direction, sat some ambiguous mass. Teague, with no other means of resolution, began steering the vessel towards the mass.

The tandem motion of the oars proved difficult to adjust to. His initial progress was slow and haphazard, infact only a mere few yards into his venture had he realized he wasn’t alone:

Sticking out from the waves was a fin, undoubtedly a sharks’, that began its advance toward Teague’s vessel. And with his sudden panic, he rapidly began steering in the opposite direction, though to his surprise, the shark idled in its present position. Teague curiously began back toward his original direction, again nearing the shark, and again it prompted his return. He thus resolved to continue toward the way for which it seemed to leave him alone.

Having traveled some distance (still toward the mass), it became clear what the mass was; a shipwreck: wood debris scattered in every which way, part of the stern protruding from the sea, a few feet into the air, whilst the bow nonexistent. The water remained clear.

OMC: “Bloody thing!

My instruments failed me!

All that planning and precision...

For what?!”

The wreckage appeared devastating: soggy sail fabric torn to bits, miscellaneous (apparently weathered) cargo sprinkled the waters. The figurehead which once stood prominently at the head of the ship, now bobbing in the water, without a vessel to guide.

CT: “What happened?”

OMC: “Why, a storm overtook the ship!

I’ve been floating here aimlessly for centuries!”

Seated on the only dry surface left; a barrel of labeled distinction, the captain had on his lap a stack of scrawled diagrams and illustrations on loose paper.

OMC: “See this now:

And the final placement of the masts took months, the keel was made of several joints of English Oak; a timber I’d *specifically* sourced myself.

And its intersection with the stern: I’d measured that intersection *eleven* times! Eleven!

My craftsman told me he was going by *feel*, as if his intuition could possibly rival mathematical certainty!”

Rather, whatever remained of the formerly grandiose ship was now mangled.

OMC: “And the precision of our predicting of eminent weather forecasting:

We’d planned on leaving the fifth, and we did.

We’d easily have reached the shores by late Winter.

The probability of a storm in the first place was infinitesimally small!

Yet suddenly it descended upon us.

It was a great storm, though my ship had the capacity to handle greater!

I’d intentionally accounted for a margin of error, I even acknowledged I wasn’t infallible!”

CT: “And you’re alone?”

OMC: “As a matter of fact; most of my men survived the initial sinking!

Yes, and they’d clung to the remains of the wreckage just as I had.

And yet, slowly one-by-one they’d let go.

Muscular fatigue maybe, though most definitely despaired at the probable outcome.

Why do I hold on?”

CT: “I’m lost too- looking for my guide!

I was just in a museum, then maybe some old storageroom, then I think maybe Hell, and now I’ve ended up here!”

OMC: “Why, the imagination is an incredible scientific feat!

Though I’m afraid I haven’t witnessed anyone cross my path in as long as I can remember!

Only one I remember was some monk whom I’d encountered during my own voyage- said he was meditating or something.

Should be just a few miles south of here.

Housed within some obscure rock formation!”

CT: “You figure he might’ve ended up there?”

OMC: “Well I’m not sure about your friend, though it’s worth a shot.

These waves are *inconquerable*.”

Thus, the *few miles* journey was to begin; Teague, back in his sailboat, began his descent down some distance. And the shark once again returned, though this time situating itself at the head of his ship; and continuing on alongside him. After some time had passed, and much-induced fatigue from the travel; a monument began to reveal itself in the distant horizon:

As it was neared, it began to take shape: an unnatural stone arch occupying an archipelago. Further towards it: a man appeared (dressed in a stereotypical toga) standing at the ends of the shoreline. Finally, he’d reached earshot:

OMS: “Well, I don’t typically anticipate visitors!”

The man, appearing middle-aged; sporting a scruffy beard and curled, messy hair, his eyes invoked an interpretation of belonging to that of a common stoic.

CT: “Please, I’m concerned for my- a friend; I can’t find him anywhere!

And I don't know where I am!"

OMS: "Let me ask; do you believe in God?"

CT: "No?

I mean, I guess I'm not sure- maybe?

What does it matter?"

OMS: "Irrespective of its significance, there must exist some natural order to it all, no?"

And the view from the monument was rather unspectacular; the tide would alternatively approach and recede amongst the rather rocky beach. The horizon appeared empty.

OMS: "I've seen many things emerge from these waters over millennia; homicidal orcas, sealions committing infanticide, men going mad over the isolation.

Though nothing nor anyone has ever left.

If it all matters, surely something would transcend the chaos, no?"

It could be observed the stoic's hands to be rather rough, though not appearing particularly unhygienic. No indication as to where he slept, nor worked, nor lived was visible; as if he'd simply stumbled into the middle of the sea!

OMS: "And so many pass by fixated on this idea of 'conquering', why?

You know, a captain once passed me a time long ago...

And he went on about how proud he was of his fine vessel...

Though if he was so infatuated with his ship, why then did he decide to use it attempt a crossing of the sea?"

Teague had no response.

OMS: "For if he was so enamored with its image, would it not serve him better fixed in a dockyard?"

CT: "I mean I guess, but he had to set sail for a reason."

OMS: "Which is?"

CT: "Well, I guess I didn't ask him."

OMS: "Figures.

So, what was this about a lost friend?"

CT: "Oh yeah- it's hard to describe what he looks like, kinda tall, though I just woke up in this boat and he was gone!

And he was supposed to guide me, and he just left!

And now I can't find him."

OMS: “Well, I haven’t seen anyone, have you checked the lighthouse?”

It’s just a few miles due west.

Besides, I don’t concern myself with *other* peoples’ problems.”

CT: “Lighthouse due south?”

Then he must be there!”

And it was that Teague began his trek now westward. The waves remained cooperative, and the shark compliant. Before too long, a lighthouse appeared:

Faded green striping against the otherwise white body, no light emanated from its top. Just as with the monument; a figure appeared near the shoreline:

OMW: “Ah, you must be lost!”

CT: “How did you know?”

OMW: “Oh, I’ve observed from this here lighthouse for a millennia-

I know when a sailor’s lost.”

The sands on the shoreline seemed forever undisturbed, the lighthouse protruded oppositionally to the otherwise flat landscape, and its painted coat had since deteriorated to the point of a flaking. The spotlight, as it turns out, was infact broken.

CT: “Yes, I’m searching for someone.”

OMW: “You came from the east.

Most do, in fact.

Though very few ever stop.

For this is but a mere waypoint.”

CT: “So where’s the destination?”

OMW: “I’m convinced there isn’t one!

Just the everchanging shifts of the equilibrium.

When I was assigned, they told me to keep eye for incoming ships...

Though it’s been so long since an encounter...

Alas, I’ve forgotten with what to do upon one!”

CT: “Isn’t your job to give directions in the first place?”

OMW: “Yes, but where to?

For this landscape bears no terrain worth traversing.

Infact, everything’s a mere waypoint!”

CT: “Aren’t you happy here?”

OMW: “That I’m not sure.

Some days I am, and some days I’m not.

And yet the sun still rises and sets just as it did the day before.

Perhaps you’d care to stay for a drink?”

CT: “I really have to continue on.

So, you haven’t seen anyone come by recently?”

OMW: “No- and perhaps further direction is not apt, rather, your best bet might be to travel from end-to-end until you’ve traversed it all!

Assuming there even exists an end to begin with!”

The sun was falling, and so visibility became even less likely, further, a fog was gradually settling on the shore. Having felt defeated in his efforts to get guidance from others, Teague retired to his boat once again. Setting off, perhaps for a final time; with no direction in mind nor any hope of finding his destination, he simply began rowing in the direction for which he came.

And after searching the seas through trial and tribulation, infact having spent the whole night rowing (as the sun’s peripheral rays began casting light above the horizon), as if a cruel prize for his efforts, another boat not too dissimilar from his own appeared amidst the mist in the distance:

DC: “I’m glad you’ve finally found me.”

CT: “And you were here the whole time?

You can’t imagine how hard I looked for you!

Please, I need to know why you’ve put me through all of this!”

Teague had rowed closer now, nearing the Divine Commentator’s vessel, and to his surprise he appeared rather refreshed.

DC: “Surely *you* know.

For you’re the one who searches perilously for whatever trivialities you choose to concern yourself with!

And what shocks the mortal man is the realization that the knowledge and the awareness is but the mere beginning!

You’ve perhaps experienced the relativity of those who, within their isolated sects, occupy but a tiny fraction of the greater whole.

And so, even if it’s *all* a relativity, my duty in this context is simply to inform you.

Tell me now; do you wish to relinquish your enactment?”

CT: “I don’t!”

DC: “So it is.

And although you may never be held in contempt for all the evil which you espouse, so long as my reign continues; you will not subvert the consequence of your choice!”

CT: “So it is.”

...

Everything is Perfect, Actually

Shrunk down to microscopic proportions, Crispian Teague’s entire existence constituted that of a mere prokaryote. More specifically, Teague’s physical form was transformed into that of a vibrio cholerae bacterium.

Presently, he- it, was swimming in a shallow stream of brackish water just north of Cap-Haitian, Haiti. It was a mangrove swamp, and within its bounds existed a thriving ecosystem: fiddler crabs in packs racing along the streambed, mudskippers, the occasional tarpon, large, manyfold roots of the red mangrove species forming what appeared to any fish at scale a submerged forest. Upon a low-angle perspective; the sun glistened across the face of the water, and mosquitos and dragonflies danced, occasionally breaking the water’s surface- the point at which Neptune and Zeus met.

It was a dastardly thing really, swimming freely among the giants, it’d pass most commonly colonies of diatoms, and on occasion, a fellow member of its own species. Then it brushed over the surface of an oyster, idly occupying a property of neatly settled sand. Nearest to this: two crabs fighting for a mate, which itself was interrupted by the rapid passing-by of a barracuda. The streambed was frequently disturbed, and masses of dead organism matter would scatter about.

There was no more commentary, for there were no more characters. There was no more dialogue, for there were no more voices. There was no more plot, for there was no more purpose.

Suddenly, a massive foot stomped through the water's surface and plunged into the streambed. The foot's owner, a human, rapidly lifted it, and Teague was caught in the residual cohesion. A nomad by nature, it was carried three tenths of a mile to the gates of a village. Those gates bore a road which led to the entryway of a home. That home held a washroom which itself possessed a cloth bathtowel. Upon its transfer to this bathtowel, it'd briefly idle until it'd succumb to the rapid onset of air asphyxiation. A meager existence indeed.